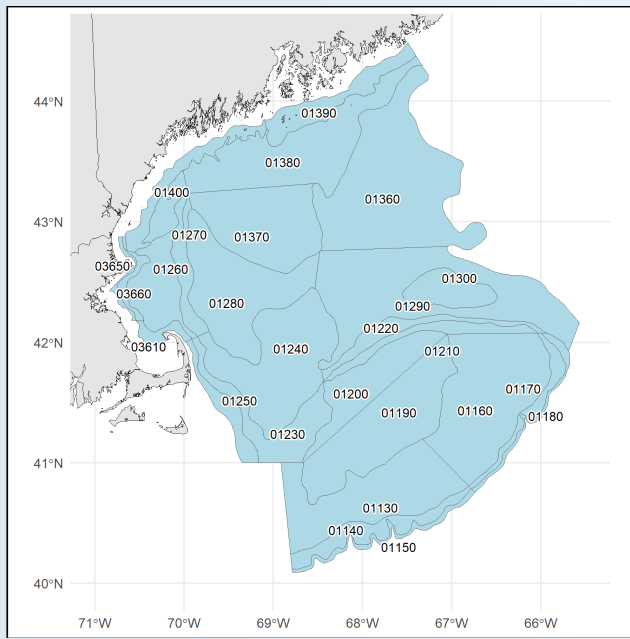




American Plaice (*Hippoglossoides platessoides*) Snapshot Ecosystem & Socioeconomic Profile

Fall 2026



This snapshot ESP provides an update to ecosystem indicators identified in the 2022 American Plaice Research Track Assessment Behan et al. (2022). This previous work found that the recruitment of plaice is related to sea surface temperature, the Atlantic Multidecadal Oscillation (AMO), and the North Atlantic Oscillation (NAO). AMO was also correlated with plaice condition. Bottom temperature anomalies, the Gulf Stream Index, and spawning stock biomass (SSB) were associated with plaice distribution. The goal of this report is to update the indicator datasets and provide context around what recent indicator data may mean for the American plaice stock, as well as highlighting recent socioeconomic information.

In the 2016 Climate Vulnerability Assessment, American plaice had an overall low vulnerability rank but high climate exposure from increasing surface temperatures and ocean acidification (Hare et al. 2016). There is evidence of American plaice shifting distribution into deeper waters (Nye et al. 2009), and further warming may decrease available habitat.

The New England Fishery Management Council (NEFMC) put American plaice under a rebuilding plan in 2004 (New England Fishery Management Council 2003) after significant declines in landings and revenue. While the number of commercial vessels landing plaice has continued to decline, revenue and landings have rebounded somewhat post-COVID19 (New England Fishery Management Council 2026) along with spawning stock biomass (Northeast Fisheries Science Center 2024).

Condition of American plaice across the Northeast Shelf exhibited lows in the 2000s to 2010, indicating thinner, lower-quality fish. Condition values have increased overall since 2010, with most recent years having neutral to good condition, and are experiencing fewer years of poor or below-average condition compared to lows in the 2000s.

